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MAHASWETA DEVI CENTENARY YEAR

THEY ONLY WANTED HER PEN

A century after her birth and a decade since her death, towering Bengali author Mahasweta Devi's greatest legacy lies in the Adivasi movements she helped build

Shrabana Chatterjee
shrabana.chatterjee@thehindu.co.in

If not for a chance encounter during his years as a rickshaw-puller, the world may never have discovered one of Bengal's most celebrated Dalit writers. At this year's *The Hindu Lit for Life*, former refugee-turned-Naxalite-turned-writer-turned-politician Manoranjan Byapari recalled giving a rickshaw ride to a bespectacled, elderly professor in a sari and jhola from Kolkata's Vijaygarh Jyotish Ray College. His inquiry into the meaning of the word *jijivisha* (enduring will to live) piqued the professor's interest. She urged him to write for *Bortika*, the

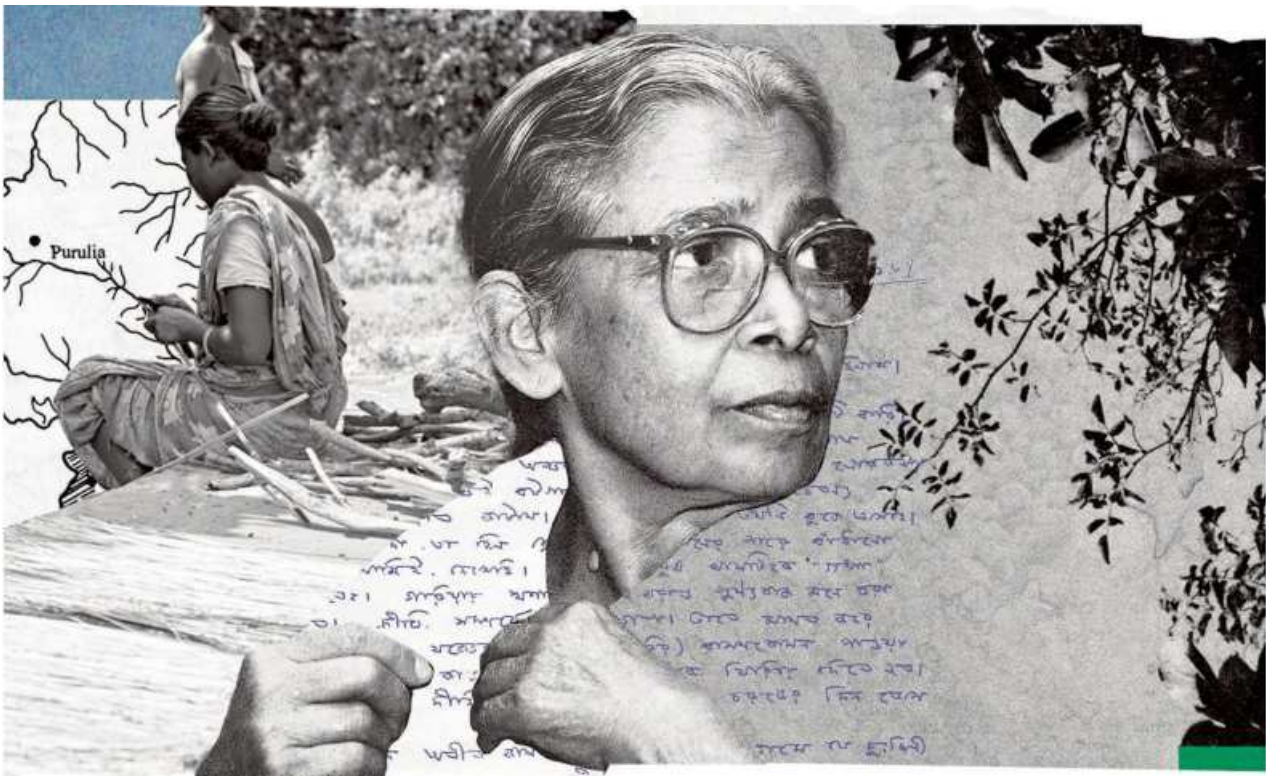


ILLUSTRATION: HITESH SONAR;
'EK JIBONEI' MANUSCRIPT
USED WITH PERMISSION

working-class magazine she edited. Before alighting, she scribbled her address on a slip of paper and signed it: Mahasweta Devi.

"Just like Goddess Saraswati emerged in front of Kalidasa, Mahasweta appeared in front of this rickshaw-wallah," Byapari said. "She recognised that a writer was hiding within me."

Over six decades, one of the foremost voices of modern Bengal's literary conscience did not simply write about the marginalised, she encouraged them to tell their own stories. This year marks Mahasweta Devi's birth centenary (January 14, 1926). A decade after her death (July 28, 2016), she remains a towering figure of Bengali literature, having written more than 100 books, around 350 short stories, and hundreds of essays, columns and reports.

Yet her greatest legacy lies beyond literature; in the

grassroots movements she helped build.

The Dhaka-born, Santiniketan-bred Mahasweta Devi spent her life writing about the lives of Adivasis and women, refusing to let history reduce them to statistics and anecdotes. Her writing was naked; she never sugar-coated the brutality of life to suit the *bhadralok* (urban elite). She shifted the centre of her gravity to the forests, prisons, tribal settlements, and student movements. She travelled everywhere with a notepad, taking running notes of life as it unfolded. For Mahasweta, writing was never the end of engagement; it was one part of a larger political practice. Nowhere is that legacy more visible than among the Kheria Sabars of Bengal's forested Purulia.

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ELITE BRIDES WANTED

PILLAI, 28, 183 cms, ME from the UK. Lives in Coimbatore. Globally educated and rooted in Indian values, he comes from a family of fine standing. An alliance is invited from a graceful, well-educated bride of similar community. Contact: 6366448343

REDDY, 29, 180 cms, MBA from the UK. Lives in Chennai. Heir to a flourishing family business and ambitious in his own right, he seeks a partner of equal grace. His family invites a cultured, well-educated bride from the same community. Contact: 6366448343

REDDY, 28, 183 cms, Software Professional. Lives in California. A Silicon Valley career balanced by strong family values. His well-established family invites a bride of grace and education from the same community, settled in the USA. Contact: 6366448343

NADAR, 28, 172 cms, Doctor — MBBS, MS, pursuing DM (Endocrinology). Lives in Chennai. A physician raised in a family of doctors, he values intellect and tradition alike. An alliance is invited from a well-educated bride of the same community. Contact: 6366448343

NAIDU, 26, 183 cms, Graduate, Entrepreneur. Lives in Chennai. Young and driven, he is building his own venture, backed by a family of considerable net worth. An alliance is invited from an accomplished, like-minded bride of a similar community. Contact: 6366448343

PADMASALI, 30, 180 cms, Entrepreneur, Master's degree. Lives in Chennai. Enterprise runs in his blood; humility defines his manner. His well-placed family seeks a like-minded, well-educated bride from a similar community. Contact: 6366448343

ELITE GROOMS WANTED

BRAHMINIYER, 27, 180 cms, Entrepreneur, Master's degree. Lives in Chennai. She builds her own venture with quiet confidence and carries her family's standing with grace. An alliance is invited from accomplished gentlemen of the same community. Contact: 6366448344

BRAHMIN/NAIDU, 33, 160 cms, BSBA, MSF. Chennai. Global finance professional, grounded in values. Family of standing. Open to Inter-caste. Seeks accomplished gentleman. Contact: 6366448344

ARYA VYSYA, 24, 163 cms, MBA, into Business. Lives in Chennai. Poised, articulate, and already a businesswoman of promise. Her family invites a well-educated groom from a similar community, preferably from a business background. Contact: 6366448344

ARYA VYSYA, 27, 158 cms, Management Professional. Lives in Bengaluru. Accomplished and gracious, the daughter of working professionals. An alliance is invited from well-educated grooms of the community, from Chennai, Bengaluru or Mumbai. Contact: 6366448344

KAMMA, 28, 165 cms, Doctor — MD & MS. Lives in Los Angeles. Brilliance in medicine, grace in everything else. Her distinguished family seeks an equally accomplished groom from the same community, settled in the USA. Contact: 6366448344

KSHATRIYA RAJU, 21, 160 cms, into Business. Lives in Bengaluru. Elegant and enterprising, born into a business family of good net worth. Her family invites a well-educated groom of standing, preferably from Bengaluru. Contact: 6366448344

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Artists perform Velakali at the Padmanabhaswamy Temple, the spiritual seat of the erstwhile Travancore royal family, in Thiruvananthapuram; and (bottom) author S. Hareesh. (PTI AND THULASI KAKKAT)

UPSIDE-DOWN HISTORY

Malayalam writer S. Hareesh reimagines Travancore’s audacious bid for sovereign nationhood after Independence

Stanley Carvalho

Alternate history, or counterfactual fiction, is hardly a novelty. For decades, writers across the world have toyed with the provocative question: ‘what if history had taken a different turn?’

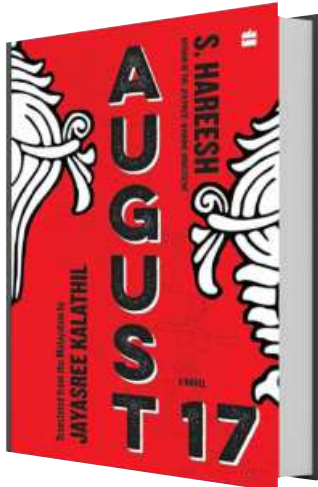
From *The Man in the High Castle* (1962) by Philip K. Dick to *1945: What If Japan hadn’t surrendered in World War II* (2007) by Robert Conroy, the genre has offered readers a chance to inhabit worlds that might have been.

Indian writers, too, have entered this imaginative terrain with notable contributions such as *The Crown of Bharat: An Alternate History of Indian Independence* (2025) by Subbiah Ramalingam and *10 Incarnations of Rebellion* (2025) by Vaishnavi Patel.

Stemming from such storied past comes *August 17*, a notable work by award-winning Malayalam writer S. Hareesh, translated into English by Jayasree Kalathil.

Thiruvithamkoor (Travancore) has been in existence since 1729 as a princely state ruled by the Travancore royal family but under the shadow of the British until 1947, after which it joined the Indian Union. But what if this state had instead become a separate free sovereign country? This gripping notion serves as the central proposition in *August 17*.

Uncertain destiny
Hareesh constructs this alternative reality with bold aplomb. The narrative is steered by an enigmatic



August 17
S. Hareesh, trs Jayasree Kalathil
Harper Perennial
₹699

spy, Bhasi, also known by other names such as Avarachan. Through his restless, peripatetic journey, the reader traverses a landscape where the real and the imagined coalesce. Historical figures walk alongside fictional characters, lending the narrative a strange authenticity even as it departs from recorded history. From the Maharaja of Thiruvithamkoor and his indomitable Diwan, Sir C.P. Ramaswami Iyer, to freedom fighters such as Akkamma Cherian, Pattom Thanu Pillai and K.C.S. Mani, and Communist leaders like K.C. George and T.V. Thomas – their

presence lends a sense of historical realism to the narrative.

Particularly compelling is the character of Basheer, a fictionalised parallel to the legendary Malayalam writer Vaikom Muhammad Basheer. In the novel, Basheer is an eccentric, part revolutionary, part literary maverick whose life revolves around politics, protests and plotting.

The novel unfolds against a backdrop of coups, revolutions, betrayals and shifting allegiances. As India closes in on freedom, the Maharaja’s refusal to join the Union sets the stage for a showdown. Appeals from leaders such as Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru fall on deaf ears. Thiruvithamkoor asserts its distinct identity. “This country,

my country, had been in existence for hundreds of years, long before even the idea of India existed. It would exist again,” says the Maharaja.

Freed from British rule, India is now divided into three countries – a democratic India, an Islamic Pakistan and a Hindu Thiruvithamkoor, each charting its own uncertain destiny.

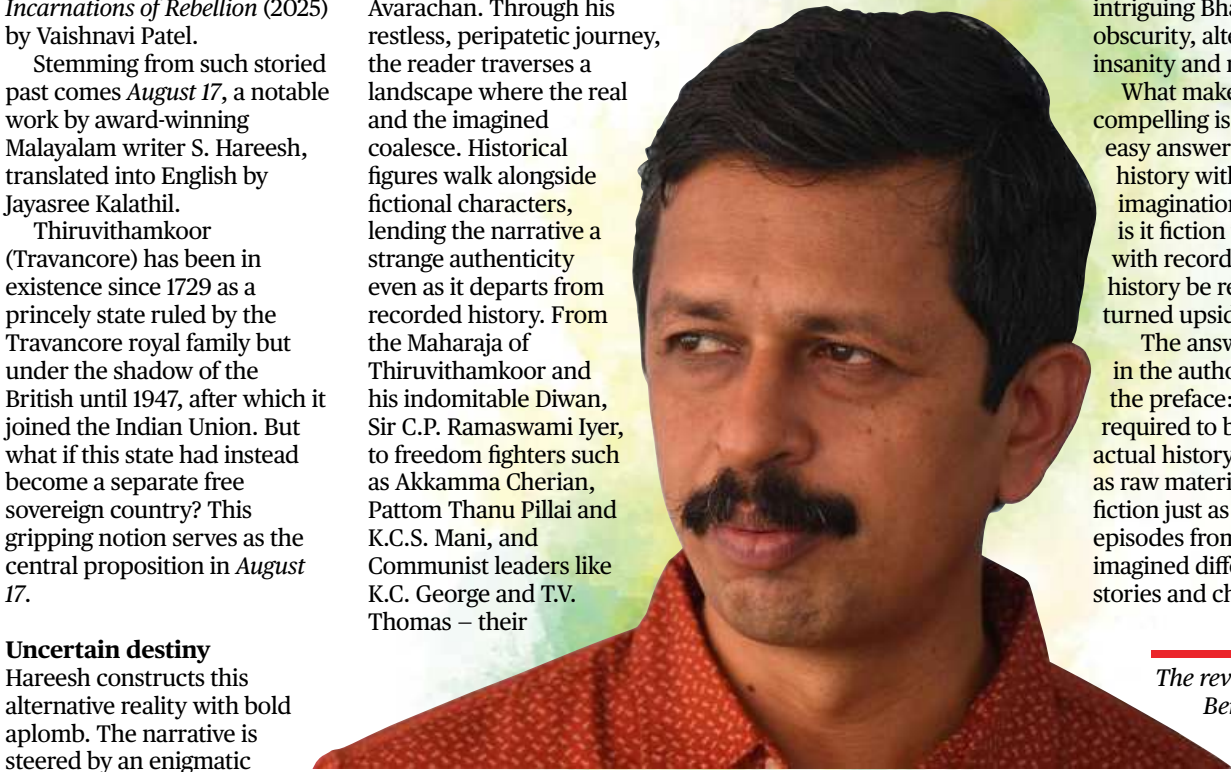
Familiar power struggles
The author doesn’t shy from confronting the political ramifications of this divergence. Messages of support come from leaders as ideologically disparate as Muhammad Ali Jinnah and Vinayak Damodar Savarkar. Assassination attempts, popular uprisings and even military confrontations ensue. In a defining incident, the Indian Army’s intervention is repelled by a fiercely nationalistic populace, emphasising the precarious nature of this imagined nation.

But independence is no bed of roses. As a sovereign state, Thiruvithamkoor inherits significant responsibilities – establishing diplomatic ties, appointing leaders, drafting policies and more. The familiar patterns of power struggles re-emerge as new leaders rise, promises of elections are made and the Communist movement gains momentum, signalling further transformation. Amid the sweeping political changes, the once influential and intriguing Bhasi sinks into obscurity, alternating between insanity and reality.

What makes *August 17* so compelling is its refusal to offer easy answers. Is this a work of history with the author’s imagination going wild? Or, is it fiction taking liberties with recorded history? Can history be rejected and turned upside down?

The answer, perhaps, lies in the author’s affirmation in the preface: “Writers are not required to be faithful to actual history but can treat it as raw material for creating fiction just as people and episodes from our lives are imagined differently to create stories and characters.”

The reviewer is a Bengaluru-based independent journalist.



Elegy for the ordinary

Elizabeth Strout crafts another quietly moving novel about grief, kindness and human connection

Cris

For all his belovedness, Arthur Dam, the protagonist of Elizabeth Strout’s new novel, *The Things We Never Say*, is not Lucy Barton – a recurring character in Strout books. There is no reason he should be, it is just a handicap of readers who look for the traits of a favourite character in every other protagonist of the writer.

There is, however, the familiar underlying niceness that Strout characters just cannot seem to escape. The Booker-shortlisted author has managed to release another helplessly adorable middle-aged man into a world where the smallest details create lasting impressions and endearments float around like a much-needed decanter.

Arthur, or Artie, is, of course, a high-school teacher – what else could he be with all that concern he harbours for the world? It fits that Artie is there to part with the history he knew of the world and open the door just a bit wider for his curious lot of 16-year-olds. He is in his late 50s and lives in Massachusetts with his wife of decades, Evie, a therapist. It also fits that Arthur is the kind of man who would have several dear friendships but comes home to share tiny details of his day with Evie.

The lurking pain

Within a few pages, Strout has moulded a man out of her prototype – kind, friendly, with an overwhelming concern for the future of his country. But everything cannot be rosy and in Strout’s words: “As many people do, Artie and Evie had suffered a tragedy.” A tragedy that has brought a distance between Artie and his son Rob. Strout does not let you gloss over the incident and head for what’s next. The tragedy has to set in, and with it, what each of the persons involved went through, has to be felt.

On the surface, it may seem like a very private affair that needn’t interest you; after all, it is in the past and all the characters appear busy with their lives. But the writing makes it hard to ignore the heaviness in their midst. Even as Evie and Artie share their stories of the day-to-day like a happy old couple, the air is thick with a misery that has permanently changed some part of them.

You can visualise every step of Artie’s descent into depression, and how well-hidden it is for a long, long time. You worry for this man, who is already shattered enough to be suicidal, when more troubling stories from the past reach him. Even as he goes on teaching, or sharing drinks with his friends, you picture him sagging and discoloured, weighed down by an uncontrollable gloom. He wonders, and



The Things We Never Say
Elizabeth Strout
Viking
₹1,099

you wonder with him, how Evie does not spot that something is wrong with him.

Beautiful relationships are formed with minimal exchanges. It can seem trivial when you read about a very ordinary moment that is made to appear important – a passing expression, a casual comment, a glance (“really looked at him”). Strout masters in subtleties. Artie’s exchanges with his students are precious, even if they are not overly enthusiastic. Strout throws such images at you now and again, until you are forced to take notice – Artie’s question to his student Rhonda; his sister with confectionery sugar; a phone call from his father. When they are repeated, they become relatable. You ransack your memories and find such seemingly insignificant moments that hold great meaning.

Politics in the mix

The only grandeur comes via Artie’s thoughts for his son and the women in his life; there is no trimming of expression. You can’t help wishing that fathers and sons had between them what Artie and Rob do.

There is also quite a bit about the 2024 American presidential elections and the doom the characters fear the country is headed for. The politics is blatantly presented, bold for a writer of today.

Strout does not have you pacing through the pages as she does with her Lucy Barton books. There is some mystery, there is a lot of emotion, but you might need Artie’s patience to take everything in. Light as the book is, the pages ask for time, and the author, very understandingly, spoils you with ellipses and white spaces.

The reviewer is a constant reader and an aspiring writer from Kerala.



A pinch of Ozeki magic

Memory, language and longing animate an uneven but rewarding short story collection

Anushree Nande

All 11 stories in Ruth Ozeki’s debut short story collection, *The Typing Lady: And Other Fictions*, feature typewriters – whether as a key narrative element, a passing reference, or a recurring motif.

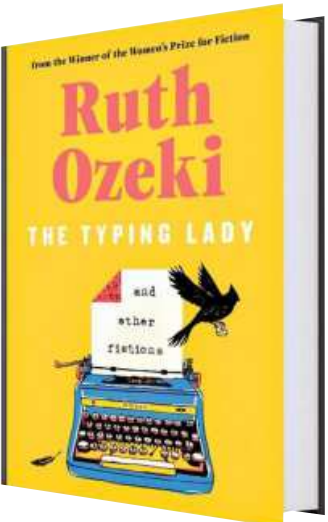
It makes sense when you realise that the anthology’s central preoccupation is with memories, storytelling and language – the ways in which

we remember, the stories we tell about ourselves and others, the inevitable gaps in those stories, what our records reveal and conceal, and how our memory shapes our very sense of self. Writing ephemera – typewriters, but also letters, manuscripts, and disappearing ink – thus become tangible manifestations of these concerns.

Other themes include environmentalism and ecology, anthropology, ageing,

loss, love, identity, delayed dreams, regrets, ambition and desire. Running through the collection is the conviction that storytelling is the ultimate connector across the space-time continuum. “Stories are how we co-create each other and dream ourselves into being,” writes the narrator of the collection’s eponymous opening story.

Blurring of voices
Ozeki carries us across the length and breadth of the



The Typing Lady: And Other Fictions
Ruth Ozeki
Canongate Books
₹1,946 (ebook)

United States, from the 1970s to the ‘90s to the early pandemic, with characters of varying ages who are mostly, if not all, academics, writers, and poets; many of them in the process of becoming or unbecoming.

A woman slowly losing her memory wants to remember her first love for the last time; another has already forgotten most of what she has lost but finds unexpected solace in a red cardinal whom she dubs the bandito; a grandmother who is also a well-known writer discusses with her teenage granddaughter how to fake her own death so she won’t have to go on her latest book tour; a couple expecting their first child cling to the hope of a flowering Santa Rosa plum; a husband spots

the ghost of his wife’s ambition wandering the woods near their home on a remote Pacific Northwest island. It is in some of these fantastical liminal spaces we get to glimpse flashes of the Ozeki magic so many readers have spoken of.

One is also struck with the preciseness of her language, and how this allows the philosophical narrative room to breathe. There is deliberation and contemplation not just in what the characters do or say, what is said about them, or even in what is left out, but also in the very manner of form and structure, the narration itself.

There is a sense, too, that if one is observant enough, it’s in the ordinary moments that extraordinary yet quiet

epiphanies reveal themselves. Though it must be said that with all the stories narrated in the first person, many intimately confidential, the author is unable to prevent the blurring of voices; unless that was the point, given that there is often a definite whiff of the autobiographical.

As with any collection, there are stories here that one loves more than the others. For a first-time reader of the Booker Prize finalist’s work, there is much to enjoy. On the whole, however, *The Typing Lady* feels rather disjointed and limited because of its repetitive tethers.

The reviewer is a Mumbai-based author and editor.

Author-activist James Baldwin; and (far right) Nicholas Boggs. (GETTY IMAGES, NOAH AND LOOF)

Gautam Bhatia

Nicholas Boggs’ *Baldwin: A Love Story* (Bloomsbury Publishing) is a new biography of the towering American novelist, playwright, essayist and civil rights activist, James Baldwin. Drawing on hitherto unexplored archives and previously unpublished material, and moving – much like Baldwin’s own life – between the American East Coast, the Deep South, Paris, Istanbul, and the French village of Saint-Paul-de-Vence, *Baldwin: A Love Story* is a brilliant new portrait of the man, his work, and his times. Edited excerpts from a conversation over Zoom:

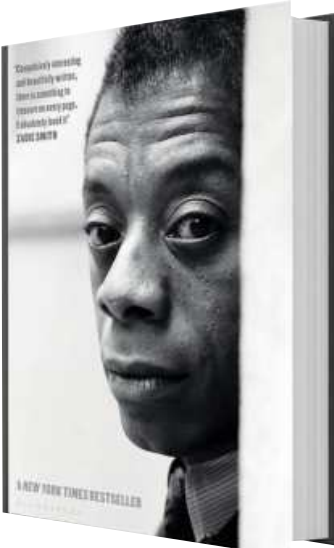
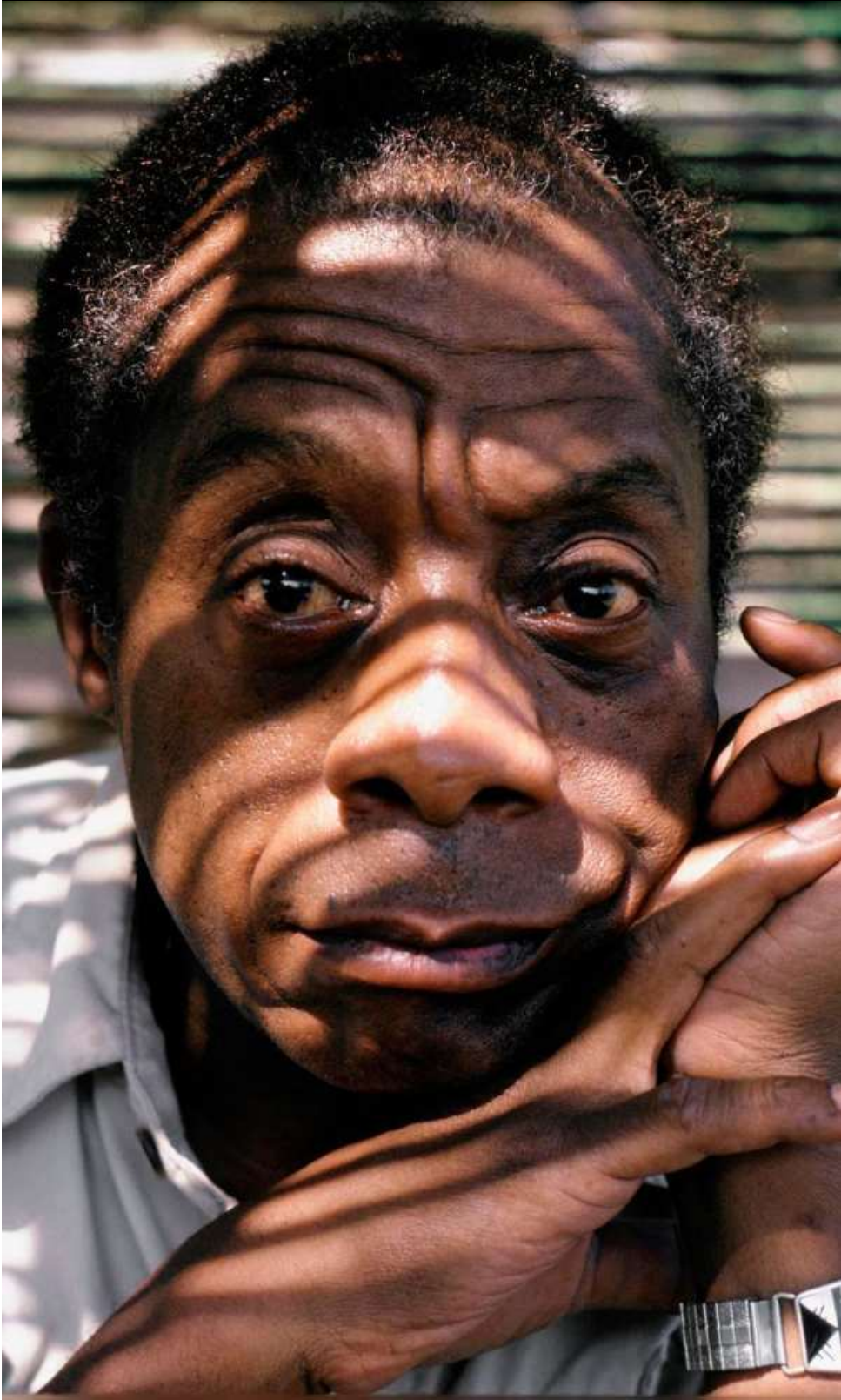
Question: Let me start by asking you about a theme that runs through your book: the relationship between Baldwin’s fiction and his non-fiction.
Answer: There is this narrative that Baldwin is a master of the essay form, which is indeed true. His fiction, meanwhile, has been treated as inferior. That is something that scholars have been arguing against for the last 20 years. As I was writing the book, I came to understand the essays and novels as intertwined.
The best example: Baldwin went to Istanbul in 1961, where he finished *Another Country*. But what I did not initially realise was that he wrote almost all of *The Fire Next Time* in Istanbul. These works are inextricable. In *Another Country*, he is looking at these messy relationships between black and white Americans and the necessity for white Americans in particular to confront their past and find a way to love their countrymen and women who



Scan the QR to watch Nicholas Boggs in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

Biographer Nicholas Boggs discusses the American writer-activist’s fiction and essays, resistance to categorisation, and enduring relevance

THE MANY LIVES OF JAMES BALDWIN



are not white. They fail to do that in the novel, but then in *The Fire Next Time*, probably one of the most important books ever written on race relations in the U.S., he is calling upon black and white Americans to come together, metaphorically, like lovers in order to change the world.

Q: You write of the swing in Baldwin’s reputation, which comes with the perceived escalation of the political in his novels, and Edward Wright’s observation that political fiction is less elegant. What struck me was Baldwin’s counter; that what makes a writer is less his respect for art and more his respect for life.
A: When *Another Country* got negative reviews, Baldwin wrote to *The New York Times* saying, “Well, you’re wrong.” And also, “I don’t judge myself by the standards of Western literature” – or in this case, the white American literary imagination. “Instead, what I’m trying to approximate is jazz and blues.”
Of course, jazz and blues is still an art form, but it is also an art form that is all about the brutalities of life and transforming them into something useful and beautiful. He has a great essay on that, *The Uses of the Blues*. The blues sensibility: yes, there is suffering, but there is also joy. There is also resilience. The entire African-American literary tradition is a story of resilience, as are the slave songs and the blues and jazz. So, I think life and art in that way are inseparable for him, but he starts with the life part, right?

Q: One thing that comes across very clearly in your book is Baldwin’s resistance to categorisation. You discuss how he wrote *If Beale Street Could Talk* from the perspective of a pregnant black woman and how Toni Morrison helped with that. How would you think of that in light of current debates around identity?
A: Great question. Baldwin was

literaryreview 03

one of the few people who defended his friend, William Styron, writing *The Confessions of Nat Turner*, which was a very controversial novel. He defended the right of anybody to write anything. But I think he also made it clear that a work of art was going to be judged. And so if you’re going to write from across cultures, for example, you have to do your research and you have to be prepared for conversations about it. Those are the kinds of conversations that, today, we need to have, but we don’t always have.
In Baldwin’s case, *If Beale Street Could Talk* is a great example of the complications he faced. Toni Morrison and Jessica B. Harris may have felt that he did well with that voice, but other black feminists like June Jordan did not. And I kind of agreed with Jordan that the voice didn’t always work, but I was interested in why. I think, in



part, it was because, as she said, “It sounded like James Baldwin.” And it sounded like Baldwin because he was voicing many of the emotions that he was feeling at the time about the man that he had dedicated the novel to, Yorlan Cazac, whose wife was pregnant at the time. So he was writing from the perspective of a black woman, but he was also unquestionably voicing his own concerns. That produced a very interesting book.

Q: How would you think of Baldwin’s work, given his writing would inevitably be read through the lens of sexuality, while he himself sought to capture what Teju Cole in his 2014 Baldwin essay would call “the incontestable

fundamentals of a person”?
A: There’s a lovely conversation on YouTube between Baldwin and Maya Angelou, where Angelou is saying that for Baldwin, homosexuality is not a noun, it’s maybe an adjective, and it’s definitely a verb, right? Baldwin was resisting all these categories by that time in his life. He didn’t want to be known just as a black writer. That doesn’t mean he wasn’t a proud black man. And he didn’t want to be known just as a gay writer. That doesn’t mean he was in the closet. He resisted all these categories. He understood that they were systems of domination. They were created by the oppressor to control people. And he claimed the right to self-determination.

Q: In your book, you talk about Baldwin’s views on Palestine and the State of Israel. In *No Name in the Street*, as early as in 1972, he presents us with a critique of Israel. A little later, he writes that commitment to black freedom would mean reordering all our commitments to support, among other things, black freedom fighters in South Africa and Angola, Cuba, the Arab nations, and so on. How would you think of Baldwin’s commitment to black emancipation in the context of his internationalist views, which were clearly at odds with the U.S. nation-state’s declared interests?
A: It’s an example of Baldwin’s idiosyncrasy and his ability to change his mind, which is something that I came to really admire about him. It is very moving to read his letters and see how his mind changes. By later in his career, he was getting into a lot of trouble. This is part of why the liberal establishment was so against him: he was not toeing the line. He wouldn’t even toe the civil rights line at the march on Washington.
He really believed in American exceptionalism early in his career. But his trip South was transformative. That’s one of the tragedies of his early death: he was getting more interesting, more international, more radical, in the good sense. If we think about trans debates today, Baldwin was writing about how we are all androgynous and each contains the other, male and female, female and male. He was exploring this in his plays and the fiction he was working on when he died.

The interviewer is a Delhi-based author, reviewer and editor.

MAHASWETA DEVI CENTENARY YEAR

My grandmother’s best books

The writer-activist once told her grandson that she was appreciated for the wrong reasons. Recalling that conversation, he lists five works that he believes are the most powerful

Tathagata Bhattacharya

My grandmother Mahasweta Devi, or Bui as I fondly called her, once said to me in a post-lunch conversation, “I am appreciated for the wrong reasons.” What she meant was that her most talked-about and celebrated works were nowhere near her best ones. So, I try to right the wrong here, based on our discussions that I can recall.

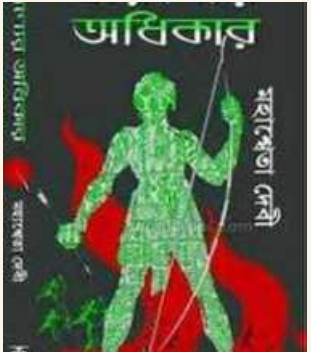
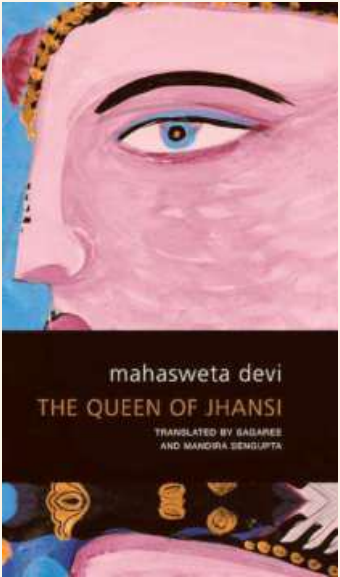
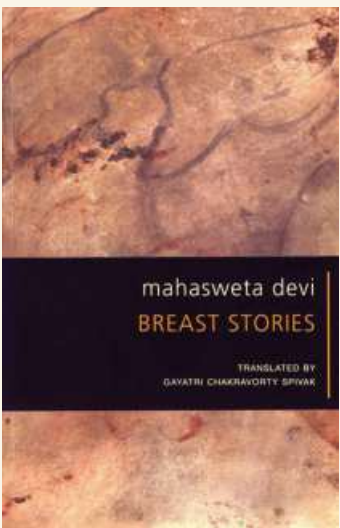
● **Breast-Giver** (*Stonodayini* [1977] in Bengali) narrates the tale of Jashoda, a Brahmin from a poor background, who works as a wet nurse in a rich Haldar family to feed her own family. As the Haldars refuse to let their own women feed their babies in the fear that they would go out of shape, Jashoda becomes a permanent milk mother. But to produce milk, Jashoda also needs to get pregnant frequently, which she does, and the children born are uncared for or given away. When Jashoda dies of breast cancer, her own family refuses to touch her body. This is one of the most powerful of Mahasweta’s works. It is a far cry from the sacred symbolism of



motherhood associated with breasts, which Mahasweta portrays as tools of labour in a quasi-feudal and quasi-capitalist society that is unjust and unequal at its roots.

● **The Queen of Jhansi** (*Jhansir Rani* [1956] in Bengali) was Mahasweta’s first novel. She travelled to every nook and cranny near Jhansi, recording songs, local histories, oral renditions, and family reminiscences about the queen. From those sources as well as mainstream research, Mahasweta wove the story of a remarkable woman who, raised as a free-spirited child and widowed at a young age, led an armed revolt that shook

the British East India Company’s rule. For any aspiring author, especially dabbling in historical fiction, this novel acts as a compass,



showing how important meticulous research is for any such project.

● **Our Non-Veg Cow** (*Golper Goru Nyadosh*) is a hilarious children’s classic. The story is about Nyadosh, a cow at Mahasweta’s father’s house, who wolfs down fried fish, and tosses policemen of the British Raj era into the river. Mahasweta has an amazing body of work for children. Fortunately for her, this was published at a time when the cow was seen more as a domesticated farm animal than a deity by society.

● **Rights of the Forest** (*Aronyer Adhikar* [1977]) narrates the struggle of the Munda tribesmen of the Chota Nagpur plateau towards

the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th century. The Mundas, though children of the forest, were deprived of it by the British Raj and a clutch of local zamindars and moneylenders. Instead, they were made to do labour. Birs Munda emerged from amongst them and led an unequal fight to reclaim the community’s freedom and rights to the forest. This is one of the most visual of Mahasweta’s novels.

● **The Life and Death of Poet Bondhghoti Gnaier Jibon o Mrityu**) is possibly my most favourite of Mahasweta’s works. Kalhan, a Chuar tribal youth, has a flair for writing poetry during the time of the Chaitanya movement. But since tribal people had no standing then, Kalhan assumed a false identity. He took the name of a Brahmin and composed the poem *Abhayamangal*. He found patronage with the king and was offered the hand of the minister’s daughter in marriage. But at the last moment, his true identity was brought to light and the king ordered his execution. The novel is a stark reminder of the tribal people’s undervaluation at the hands of a feudal and casteist society. This work will soon be available in translation from Seagull Books.

The New Delhi-based writer is the author of General Firebrand and His Red Atlas.

CONTINUED FROM » PAGE 1

A community remembers The traditionally landless, nomadic hunter-gatherers still remember how their Maa (mother) worked tirelessly for their dignity and fought bureaucracies as fiercely as she wrote about injustice. The Kheria Sabars are one of India's denotified tribes, branded "born criminals" under the British colonial Criminal Tribes Act of 1871.

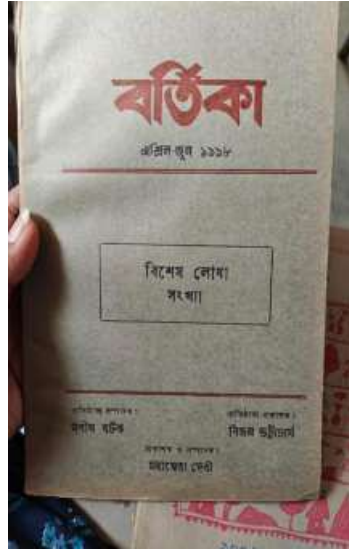
In Rajnawagarh area, a two-room mud house called 'Mahasweta Bhawan' preserves her bed, her books, and her photographs on the walls. Her close confidant Prasanta Rakshit, 66, has lived here over four decades.

On November 10, 1983, Rakshit accompanied Mahasweta to a Sabar mela (fair) in Maldih village. There, they met Paschim Banga Kheria Sabar Kalyan Samity founder Gopiballav Singdeo. The community-based Samity works for the welfare of the Sabars of Purulia and Bankura districts.

Rakshit never left. As the director of the Samity next door, he continues Didi's (elder sister) work: assists families with land records, legal cases, government paperwork, runs a girls' hostel, etc.

Recalling how Didi's writings redefined life for thousands, Rakshit says, "We just wanted her pen." Singdeo invited Mahasweta to write about the community's trials. The Adivasis, too, wanted the power of her pen.

Beyond the pages For the Sabars, Mahasweta's writing was never confined to books. "She never asked anyone for a single favour for herself.



She also wasn't alive when the shackles were removed from tribal leader and freedom fighter Birsa Munda's sculpture in Ranchi's Birsa Chowk. She'd raised the issue at a meeting in early '80s, remembers Achintya Ganguly, a senior journalist from Jharkhand.

Yet, in the villages where she once walked, people insist her work never really ended.

Voices from the ground Jaladhar, who lives in the Kuda hamlet, far away from the rest of the habitation, is an example of how deeply Mahasweta shaped lives on the ground.

In 1968, it was in his courtyard, where the Sabars from Bengal, Jharkhand, and Odisha gathered for the first time, organising against the atrocities they faced. This is where the Samity was born.

Jaladhar, whose father failed to send him for his class X exams for the lack of ₹50 and five kilograms of rice, what constituted fees in those days, instead held Mahasweta's hand since 1983 to work for his community. Today, as the Samity's secretary, Jaladhar redefines how society sees the young people of his tribe.

From once shunned as "thieves" and untouchables, and not allowed to wear clothes (besides a small loin cloth), Sabars are now graduates, school teachers and artists, preserving their indigenous knowledge and craft. However, change remains incomplete. Many are first-generation learners and are struggling to find stable livelihoods, often relying on minor odd jobs.

That belief in self-representation defined Mahasweta's politics as much as her writing. Like Byapari, Ranchi-based Oraon writer Mahadev Toppo credits her



To construct her like a Mother Teresa-like figure is the worst mistake... When I met her in 1979, I met an imposing person obsessed with helping tribal people, often with the notion of top-down philanthropy, indefatigable as an activist journalist, excellent at scaring the police... When I knew her, she was only working with the Sabars... the question of finishing a struggle is a bit unreal. In this area, one works without the hope of finishing anything

GAYATRI CHAKRAVORTY SPIVAK Scholar, critic, theorist, translator. She's one of Mahasweta Devi's first translators, who met the veteran author as a fellow activist

with urging him to write. She'd often tell him, "No matter how big or small, Toppo, write about whatever aches your heart, one day your small idea will also become big. You must write about your community."

She offered the same encouragement to Sabar writers through Bartika, her now-out-of-print quarterly Bengali magazine that was once helmed by her radical poet-writer father Manish Ghatak. She let their stories go unedited, much like how she never "let newspapers in Kolkata edit her stories", Rakshit adds.

Living her characters Mahasweta's immersion in the lives she wrote about was neither performative nor at a remove. She lived among, and kept returning to, the community.

Rakshit recalls once criticising a 37-page manuscript she'd written in the local dialect of Purulia, which was not her native tongue. "When asked for feedback, I told her it felt synthetic," he says. Mahasweta quietly tore it all up and threw it in the dustbin. "I was concerned that I may have overstepped. But she wasn't bitter. She rewrote the entire piece in the Bengali she spoke," he adds. That willingness to listen shaped her literature as much as her activism.

In novels like Aranyer Adhikar (Right to the Forest, 1977) and Chhotti Munda Eborg



New, younger, unrelated people are taking an interest in her work because the names may have changed, but the fear and concerns of the people are still the same as when she wrote about them

NAVEEN KISHORE Mahasweta Devi's close friend, and publisher at Seagull Books

Disquiet at home

Mahasweta Devi, to borrow Spivak's words, "comes from the so-called Bengal Renaissance". And yet, her own life was far removed from literary romanticism. Born in Dhaka, in a prominent Bengali literary family (social worker-writer mother, poet-writer father, and arthouse filmmaker-uncle Ritwik Ghatak), she recalled, on a Doordarshan TV interview, about marrying into "poverty and struggle". "That was my first-hand experience with the other side of the society," she said. During those difficult years, she worked as a teacher, sold soap and tea leaves, and even had a failed attempt at supplying research monkeys to the U.S.

Her "real inspiration to writing", she recalled in the interview, came in 1950s Bombay, where her then husband, playwright-actor and Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA) founder member Bijon Bhattacharya, was writing the screenplay for the Vyjayanthimala-starrer Nagin (1954).

In Bombay, she read V.S. Savarkar's 1909 book, The Indian War of Independence of 1857. The section on Rani of Jhansi sparked what she later called "a mad desire" to write the queen's biography. She learnt Marathi, consulted the queen's nephew, travelled extensively in Madhya Pradesh, and combined archival research with oral histories of ordinary soldiers, women, Dalit communities, etc. Her debut, Jhansirani (1956), birthed a writer who challenged elite nationalism.

Her complicated relationship with her son [Nabarun Bhattacharya aka Bappa, estranged since her divorce], however, pricked her for a lifetime. Mahasweta regretted it, but in the bigger scheme of things, she had so many priorities that fights and turbulence of relationships were not something she harboured in her heart for long. By the end of her life, dementia had set in, and it was all a fog, says Kishore.



She wrote in Bengali but many of her works did not solely focus on Bengal-centric issues. Her work was universal — filled with universal thoughts and struggles, not limited to one place. Her use of language, her fabulous dialogue resonates with readers across generations. She wrote fearlessly and truthfully. These two things helped her voice to be heard

ARUNAVA SINHA Translator

Tar Teer (Chhotti Munda and His Arrow, 1979), and short story Drupadi (1981), she chronicled dispossession, state violence, caste oppression, and Adivasi resistance with a realism that was unusual in Indian literature. "Many have written about Adivasis while sitting in cities," says Ranendra, Ranchi-based former director of the Tribal Research Institute in Jharkhand. "Mahasweta wrote from the ground." He points to Drupadi, where Dopei Meihen's refusal to clothe herself after custodial rape transforms her violated body into an act of resistance. "From the pages of the book, it became a revolution on the ground... This was

Mahasweta's achievement," Ranendra says.

She also turned her gaze towards urban Bengal. Set against the backdrop of the '70s Naxalite movement, her 1974 novella Hajar Churashir Maa (Mother of 1084) — which Govind Nihalan adapted into a film starring Jaya Bachchan and Anupam Kher in 1998 — examined political violence, motherhood and the moral failures of Bengali bhadralok (upper- and middle-classes).

Echoes of an enduring life Bengal, however, shied away from giving her State literary awards, even as it had awarded her estranged, radical writer-son Nabarun Bhattacharya years ago.

Mahasweta won several national and international honours, including the Jnanpith Award (1996), Ramon Magsaysay Award (1997), Sahitya Akademi Award (1979), Padma Shri (1986), and Padma Vibhushan (2006), among others. But awards didn't define her. Rakshit says, the prize money found its way back to the work on the ground through the Samity.

Her commitment also made her politically inconvenient. The lifelong Marxist questioned governments of every persuasion, from the Left party to Trinamool Congress (TMC), after supporting the TMC-led movement against land acquisition in Singur and Nandigram in the late 2000s.

She challenged bureaucrats and publicly intervened whenever the State failed the dispossessed. "The Left party that they grew up with refused to introspect, and she felt the change... But going forward, she was also disappointed with the Mamata regime and eventually distanced herself from them," says her friend and publisher Naveen Kishore.

Retired Delhi University professor Nandita Basu, now based in the U.S., who met Mahasweta in the '80s, remembers her as saying: "It is not an easy task for a woman writer to take on the authority of the State on multiple occasions." Prof. Basu adds, "Before her, many others had written about tribal suffering. Mahasweta also wrote about resistance from within the community; that is inspiring."

So relentless was her intervention that admirers jokingly called it the "Mahasweta government" — not an institution but a woman with a pen, a stack of letterheads and an unwavering refusal to let bureaucratic indifference go unchallenged. Hundreds of Adivasis who came to Kolkata seeking help, knew they could knock on the door of her Ballygunge home. She ensured they never left her house hungry.

Today, as Adivasis in Madhya Pradesh affected by the Ken-Betwa river-linking project stage a 'Chita Andolan' (funeral pyre protest), Mahasweta's words speak louder than ever. Her work echoes in Bengal and Jharkhand's villages, where people remember her not just as a literary icon but as their Didi or Maa, who stood beside them when few others did.

And, "they only wanted her pen".

Mahasweta Devi, photographed at her residence by Naveen Kishore; and (below) the two of them at the Jaipur Literature Festival, 2013. (NAVEEN KISHORE AND GETTY IMAGES)



Scan the QR code to watch a documentary featuring Mahasweta Devi and Naveen Kishore on magazine.thehindu.com

Naveen Kishore

Writing as intimacy. As 'surrender', as in totally drowning in the act of writing. 'Loving' the language enough to completely immerse yourself in it. No place for the self as 'ego' or 'personality' with its own views. To be 'possessed' by the spirit of the language of literature. Writing, therefore, as 'activism'.

Writing also as relationship. Not just between two people. But with the freedom she allowed her characters. Or mukti as she called it. Often in the context of the belief that her characters had the right to dream their own paths. Choose their own fates. Regardless of the consequences, which would lead to some amazing stories where the reader often forgot the writer. The writer as a clandestine presence? Maybe.

Mahasweta Devi's ability to combine the fact of his daily life with her fiction. And her activism that instinctively made her decipher realities and then translate them into a literature of resistance. Not just as an extension of her own 'fighter'

self but also as a human being with an evolving concerned vision. Writing as an act of intuition. A desperate storytelling that does not always position itself in the objective. It is personal. And political. It is left to the reader to find motivation or strategy or allusion or method in her texts.

"Writing became my real world for me, in which I lived and survived," she said.

We read to each other. Poems, texts that qualified as jottings. She insisted I write. Every single day. And made me send her texts — long, short, anything I did that day — for 30 days to start me off.

Our conversations were meanderings in an otherwise vast and unfolding "interruptus". Life.

And in her case, all the 'throwing herself into the fray' on behalf of the tribal community, for instance. Fighting battles with the police on their behalf. And yet we talked. We joked about death in the same breath as we joked about wanting to hover over our own wake.

She hated 'good people'. Had no time for them. Often said to me: "You must promise me that you will not change into a good person."

"What happens to belief when it is betrayed?" I suddenly said aloud to her.

"About belief — I have never found any reason to feel negative or pessimistic. The old values are alright for me and I see no reason

to depart from them. You see the way I stay. You've seen me before too, you see it now. And I'm not doing a lot, I'm not doing anything great. This is the least I can do. I don't even feel the urge to be otherwise. People talk about my being a Naxalite sympathiser. Yes, I sympathise with them for sacrificing their lives. For a belief. Even when they knew that writing a slogan on the wall would court a bullet from the police, they did it. They were young jewels. The Party just used these people and threw them away. And forgot all about them. They are looking forward to my death so that they can slip in and give me a State funeral. I won't give them that chance."

"They've become part of my system," she said. "I've been able to get a glimpse of a vast human society — tribal and non-tribal, all of them. Also, because I wrote for newspapers — investigative sort of

A sense of self that instinctively didn't 'lean' on anyone. Not out of pride. Just a matter-of-fact way of being woman-human. And remember, she learned survival very early in a man's world. I once asked her: "Don't you feel lost sometimes? Because I get the feeling that you are haunted by so many ghosts and characters and people — I suppose all of us are. But with you it is slightly different, because they are almost like entire scenarios of books that you have done."

"They've become part of my system," she said. "I've been able to get a glimpse of a vast human society — tribal and non-tribal, all of them. Also, because I wrote for newspapers — investigative sort of

writing, I often say that my world is divided between two things — the needful and the needless. I am interested only in the former. I don't have much use for the needless."

Soon, the nature of the conversations would change. Even grind to a halt. To be replaced by shorter visits. No recorded interviews. Or cameras for black-and-white photographs. She would still smile. And recognise. And do what we call aador to my arm as if to say you are loved. But already the fog in her mind was becoming a welcoming place. A slow dementia that would only grow worse.

Yet, a few years ago, delivering the keynote address at the Jaipur Literature Festival, she said:

"At eighty-eight or is it seven I move forward often stepping back into the shadows. Sometimes I am bold enough to step back into the sunlight. As a young person, as a mother, I would often move forward to when I was old. Amuse my son. Pretend that I couldn't hear, or see. Flail my hands about like in a blind man's game, or make mockery of memory. Forget important things. Things that had taken place but a moment ago! These games were for fun. Now

they are no longer funny. My life has moved forward and is repeating itself. I am repeating myself. Recollecting for you what has been. What is. What could have been. May have been. Now it's Memory's turn to mock me."

A poem for 'Hazaar Chaurasi ki Maa' the mandolin plays the night the street waits for the girl to walk all over it the girl takes her chalk and slits the street's unwilling throat ek-hat - du-hat ek-hat - du-hat she hops from one numbered square to another us n them us n them, she mutters turns on number ten and hops back on bloody feet the man finishes clothing the naked mannequin with care whips out a pistol and shoots it in the eye once twice three times day after day she wakes up to her breathlessness.

The writer is a photographer, theatre lighting designer, poet, and the publisher of Seagull Books.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty

LIFE LESSONS FROM MOTHS

①FAKE IT TILL YOU MAKE IT!

Not a snake, but a Hawk moth caterpillar

②ONLY ON REFLECTING INWARD WILL YOU MAKE A SWEEPING STRIDE

The Looper Moth caterpillar

③YOUR BAGGAGE IS YOURS ALONE TO CARRY

The Bogworm Moth caterpillar

④ONE'S GOT TO WATCH ONE'S OWN BACK

The Outlet Moth

⑤EVEN IF YOU RESEMBLE BIRD POOP, SOMEONE, SOMEWHERE WILL FIND YOU PRETTY

The Beautiful Wood Nymph

⑥THERE'S NO 'I' IN 'TEAM'

The Oak Processionary Moth caterpillars

⑦A TRUE FRIEND IS A REFUGE

The Sluth Moth which lives exclusively in sloth fur

⑧TRIGONOMETRY IS ACTUALLY APPLICABLE TO LIFE!

The Luna Moth deflecting bat sonar

⑨EVERY OCCASION IS AN OCCASION FOR FLASHY UNDERWEAR

The Yellow Underwing Moth

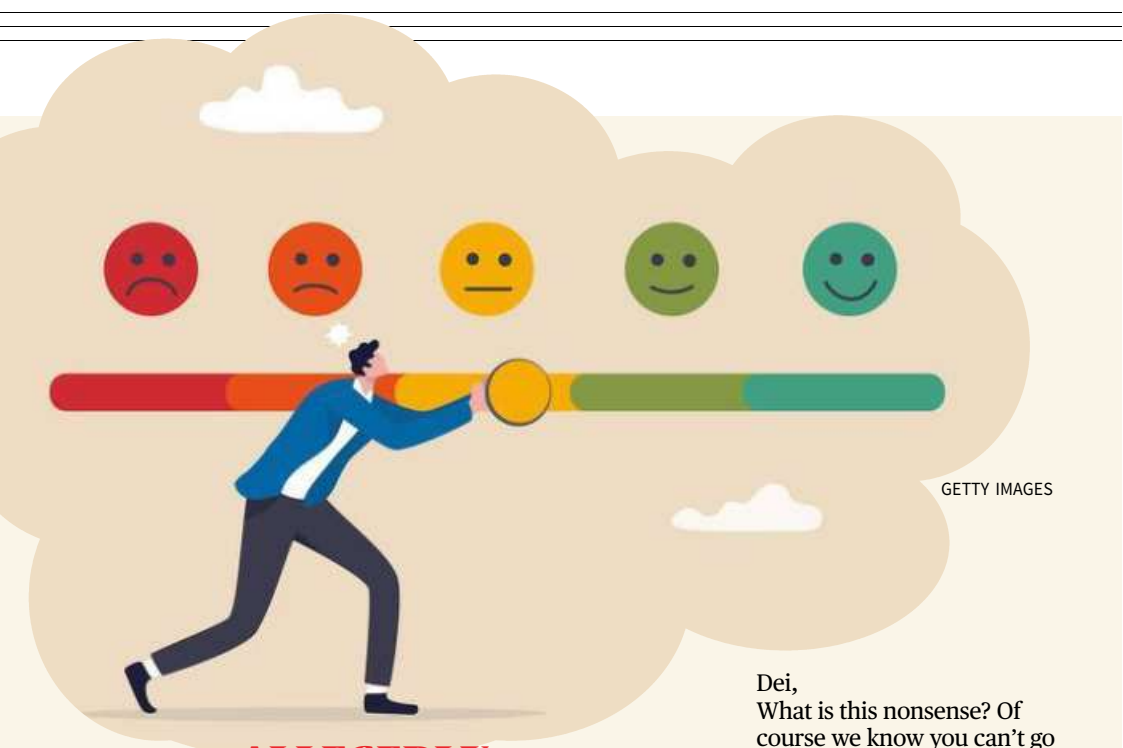
HAPPY MOTH WEEK!

Dear Most Valued Customer, Thank you for choosing New India Elite Automotive Salvation for servicing your esteemed vehicle. Our records show that you have not filled our Customer Satisfaction Survey. Your feedback is important to us. It will help us understand what we did well, document where we can improve, and identify outstanding employees who we can lay off. Please note that the information you share will be kept confidential and your data will be used solely for the purpose of improving our services (and our revenues) by having our sales team auction them to reputed data-mining specialists. Thank you for your continued trust in us. — NIEAS Customer Satisfaction Team

Dear Valued Customer, It's been 45 minutes since we returned your car to you. You have still not filled the feedback form. We request you to take this seriously. The survey should take only a few hours to complete. Thank you once again for your time. — NIEAS Customer Delight Team

Dear Customer, Thank you for informing us that you've already filled a hardcore survey form at the service centre. But that feedback form covers only the Service Advisor Interaction and not the entire NIEAS experience. You must have received a link to SurveyDonkey on WhatsApp, SMS and email. Please click on the link and complete the online survey. — NIEAS Customer Joy Team

Dear Sir, Thank you for letting us know that our Customer Satisfaction questionnaire is "too long, too complicated, and as difficult as an unlearned NEET question paper". We are, however, disappointed that you did not even attempt half the questions. Please note that there are no right or wrong answers, and on successful completion of the survey, you will



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get 500 loyalty points, which you can convert into 500 euros any time you wish to access our services in France.

We strongly urge you to complete our Customer Satisfaction Survey ASAP. — NIEAS Customer Pleasure Team

Hello!!! We have been calling you every 15 minutes for the past 15 days and you are simply not answering! Not only are you uncooperative, you have blocked all the 105 different numbers used by the seven members of our small Customer Pleasure Team (we typically provide only 15 SIM cards per employee).

May we remind you that the software updates we installed last year in your car's infotainment system enable us to record everything you gossip about while driving and also track your non-stop. With your driving history and integrated AI, we can predict exactly where you will be at any given moment. You do not want to

antagonise us. Fill the feedback form NOW! — NIEAS Customer Bliss Team

Hello Mister, Thank you for finally filling in all 743 pages of our interview form. We are delighted to note that you are 'Very Satisfied' with the quality of our service, that you 'Strongly Agree' that our pricing was 'Reasonable' and that you found the cleanliness and comfort of the Waiting Area to be 'Excellent'.

But we are shocked that you have rated the 'Overall NIEAS Experience' as only 'outstanding' and not, as we were expecting, 'too good to be true'. Frankly, we were expecting a rating of at least 'mind-blowing', if not 'out of this world'. As you are surely aware, a lot, including our performance bonus, depends on the ratings we get. So go back to the survey and change this one rating so we can close this. — NIEAS Customer Euphoria Team

Dei, What is this nonsense? Of course we know you can't go back and change just one answer, and that you have to do the whole survey all over again to change your response to Q.493 — that is part of our security protocol. So what if it is tedious? Just do it again — unless you want to suffer the consequences of calling us "outstanding" — NIEAS Customer Rapture Team

Dear Mr. Samaaph, Congratulations! You have finished our survey! Having carefully reviewed your responses, we regret to inform you that NIEAS staffers who interacted with you have found your answers to be 'below expectations'. Accordingly, we are withdrawing the 0.05% special discount we had provided on engine oil, lubricants, car shampoo and nail polish. As per our new bill (enclosed), please transfer the remainder amount due, totalling ₹99,476.

Also, please click on the link to a feedback form that we've sent you by WhatsApp, SMS and email and share your feedback on the experience of giving us your feedback.

Looking forward to serving you again. — NIEAS Customer Ecstasy Team

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 34

EAST OR WEST, INDIA IS THE BEST

Once the debate is about who we are, it's no longer about what went wrong

Dear readers, some years ago, I went on a business trip to Switzerland with a colleague. Which sounds very fancy, no doubt. Oh, look at Sidin, flaunting his flashy international lifestyle while I am stuck in traffic, it has been raining non-stop for three days, I am trying to distract myself by reading this newspaper, and this rascal is talking about his trip to Geneva.

Please be patient. There will be further reasons to take things personally as you read this column. Hold your ire, I beg you.

So, we were in Geneva. This was sometime in 2011-12. Due to various logistical reasons, my colleague and I were travelling separately. I arrived in Geneva, and then at the hotel, only to discover that my colleague had booked both of us into a single room.

What nonsense, I said. Surely the company was paying for two rooms? Yes, he said. But this way, we could save money on the expenses, and have more left for shopping, food, beverages, and other such jollies.

Which was fine. But there was just one problem, dear readers. The hotel had allocated a room for us that was usually allocated to couples. By which, I mean adults engaged in some sort of romantic relationship. And one feature of this was the fact that the bathing cubicle did not have walls. Instead, it was surrounded on three sides by frosted glass panels. If any one person was using the shower, the other would be subjected to fuzzy but still very lifelike silhouette of the showering individual.

My colleague and I were friends. But not that friendly. We immediately agreed to vacate the room when the other person was



Carrier Extension-I (2024) by Yogesh Ramkrishna. (COURTESY LATITUDE 28)

partaking of the facilities.

To this day, the memory sends a shiver up and down my spine.

Anyway. The next morning, we went down to the dining room for breakfast. And were immediately surrounded by a very large, and very boisterous, group of Indian tourists.

The vast majority of these tourists was perfectly normal. The children, especially, were very well behaved. But there were two men who were really quite obnoxious. And it was clear that their co-travellers were quite embarrassed by their shenanigans.

“Those two fellows are

unbearable, no?” I said to my colleague.

He nodded in agreement. “The Indian government should ban such people from travelling abroad. They just make all of us look bad.”

And then we proceeded to have a pointed breakfast conversation about civic sense, public behaviour and decorum. And then as we got up to leave, one of the obnoxious men came over to our table.

“Are you also from India,” he asked. Yes, we said. And then we made some polite small talk, shared tips on local tourist spots. And then it transpired that the man was from

National cryway
/ˈnæʃənəl ˈkraɪweɪ/
noun
plural: national cryways

Definition: The extremely narrow conversational passage between a problem being acknowledged as a problem and that problem being declared a matter of identity or politics, within which two Indians can briefly discuss a national shortcoming without hostilities. Like all national infrastructure, it is prone to sudden closure without notice.

Related forms:
Cryway closure (*noun*): The abrupt end of honest discussion, typically triggered by a foreign comparison.
Crywayfarer (*noun*): A person attempting to navigate a complaint through the national cryway.

the exact same State in India as my colleague. They bonded briefly, but enthusiastically, and then the both of us ran to catch a tram for our business meetings.

On the tram, I made a fatal mistake. I should have known better. But I erred. “That dude was so weird, no?” I told my colleague, assuming we both still agreed that he was obnoxious.

“No! I think he was a good guy.”

There was a soft thud as my jaw hit the floor of the Geneva tram. I quickly reeled it back in.

“Sidin, we are too harsh on Indian tourists. Do we say the same when we see tourists from other countries? Of course not. I think it is a colonial mindset.”

I never brought it up again. Until today. But only with you. Because in the years since then, I have discovered that there is a very thin opportunity to discuss Indian problems with other Indian people. That opportunity lies between two points of perception.

Firstly, the problem should be perceived as a problem. Then, you can have a discussion. But then the problem should never be framed as a matter of identity or politics. Because the moment it turns into one of those, the discussion is over.

So, for instance, you can say that roads in India are bad and full of potholes. But if you say that roads in Nairobi or Colombo are better? Finished. Immediately conversation will fall apart like a road in some other country, definitely not India.

It is only in that tiny space between a problem being a problem, but a problem not being a political or identity problem, that we can actually discuss it without fisticuffs and absolute shenanigans.

And I think it is time we came up with a term for this small gap. And that term is: national cryway.

Example sentence: “Ajay and I were making excellent progress on the subject of airports, but the moment I mentioned that Naples airport was 15 Arab crore times better than Chennai, the national cryway was shut down with immediate effect.”

What do you think, reader? Is this a problem only in India? OK, please calm down.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

Bob Jones

Today's deal is from a recent match between a team from Italy and a team from Norway. All the players were top tier. Declarer won the opening diamond lead in dummy with the ace, led a heart to his ace, and cashed the king of hearts to draw the last trump. He cashed dummy's ace and king of spades and ruffed a diamond back to his hand. He cashed the queen of spades,

GOREN BRIDGE

Great play, no reward

North-South vulnerable, East deals

discarding a club from dummy, and exited with a low club. Had West played the jack, East would have been endplayed with the king and forced to give a ruff-sluff, presenting declarer with his doubled contract. West

was Italian Giovanni Donati, and he rose with his ace of clubs, swallowing East's king, and cashed two more clubs for down one. Outstanding play!

At the other table, they reached the same contract but

not doubled. The timing was slightly different. Declarer ruffed a diamond at trick two and then played the ace and king of hearts and then the ace and king of spades. He crossed back to his hand with a trump and East, Norway's Boye Brogeland, discarded the king of clubs! This would have been crucial if partner's clubs were acequeen-10 instead of ace-queen-jack. It was a brilliant play that did not gain for his team, but we can still admire the excellent defense at both tables.

NORTH
♠ A K
♥ 10 8 6 2
♦ A 4
♣ 8 5 4 3 2

WEST
♠ J 8 4 2
♥ 3
♦ 10 7 5 2
♣ A Q J 7

SOUTH
♠ Q 9 6
♥ A K J 9 7 4
♦ 9
♣ 10 9 6

EAST
♠ 10 7 5 3
♥ Q 5
♦ K Q J 8 6 3
♣ K

The bidding:
EAST 1♦
SOUTH 1♥
WEST 4♣
NORTH 4♥
Pass
Pass
Pass
*Negative

Opening lead: Five of ♦

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has July 19 ever given us?



The Airbus Beluga, which is used to transport aircraft parts and outsize cargo. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 On July 19, 1595, Johannes Kepler had an epiphany while teaching in Graz, Austria, leading him to develop his theory of the geometrical basis of the universe. A decade later, he made the revolutionary discovery that planets do not travel in perfect circles. What shape do they follow?

2 On July 19, 1877, Spencer Gore, a first-class cricketer and rackets player, won the inaugural event held at the All England Lawn Tennis and Croquet Club in London. By what name do we now know this event, better known by the name of the London district where it is held?

3 Born on July 19, 1894, Percy Spencer was a self-taught

physicist who went on to lead the radar division during World War II. One day, he noticed that the chocolate bar in his pocket melted in front of a magnetron he was building. Based on this experience, what did he go on to invent?

4 On July 19, 1903, Maurice Garin, who worked as a chimney sweep, took part in a bicycle race organised to promote a newspaper. It was held for 19 days with a daily allowance, and Garin eventually won 3,000 francs for coming first. How better do we know this now annual race?

5 On July 19, 1922, American swimmer Johnny Weissmuller became the first person to break the one-minute barrier for 100m freestyle. He went to Hollywood and played an iconic figure onscreen. What character, known

more for swinging between trees than swimming, is he famous for playing?

6 On July 19, 1941, the BBC World Service played an iconic piece of music to launch Britain's 'V for Victory' campaign. The opening four notes of this symphonic piece matched the Morse code for the letter 'V' (...-). Ironically, which German composer's 'Fifth Symphony' was this?

7 On July 19, 1941, the cartoon 'The Midnight Snack' by William Hanna and Joseph Barbera was released. It featured a warring cat and mouse, with the latter victorious over the cat, who winds up in the refrigerator. This was the first episode in which the two central characters were given names. What were their names?

8 Born on July 19, 1947, Sir Brian Harold May is an animal welfare activist and astrophysicist. He is globally famous for being the founding guitarist of one of the most popular British rock bands of all time. Which band, known for making entire stadiums clap in unison, did he co-found?

9 On July 19, 1977, at 12.41 a.m., Navigation Technology Satellite-2 transmitted a low-power radio transmission signal, which was received at Rockwell Collins in Cedar Rapids, Iowa. This marked the beginning of a satellite navigation system that is now used around the world. Although created and controlled by the U.S. Department of Defense, it is freely accessible to anyone. What system is this?

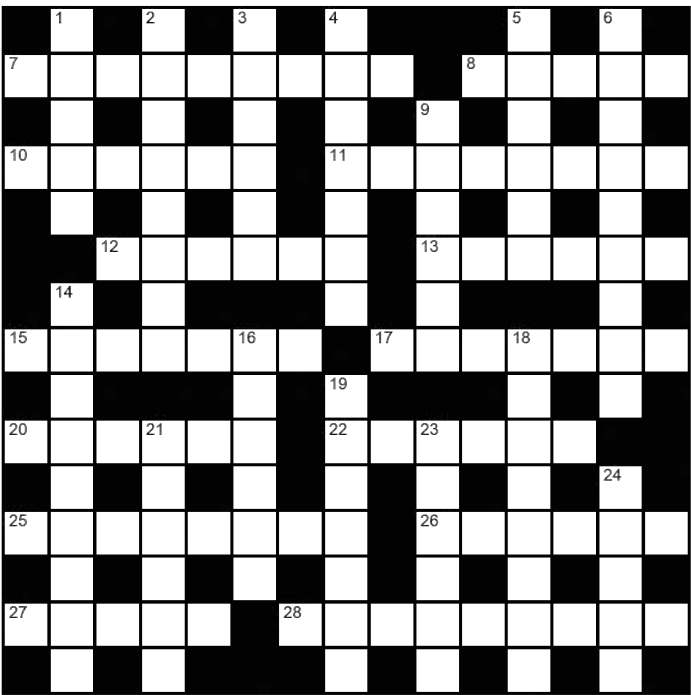
10 On July 19, 2018, an Airbus Beluga XL made its first flight. These oversized aircraft were designed to transport aircraft parts. The name is a reference to their distinctive shape, and they are painted to further reinforce the image. This makes them look like what animal in the sky?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. Ellipses (elliptical orbits)
- 2. Microwave oven
- 3. Tom and Jerry
- 4. Tom and Jerry
- 5. Tarzan
- 6. Beethoven
- 7. Tom and Jerry
- 8. Queen
- 9. GPS (Global Positioning System)
- 10. Beluga whale

Answers

THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 65 (Set by Vidwan)

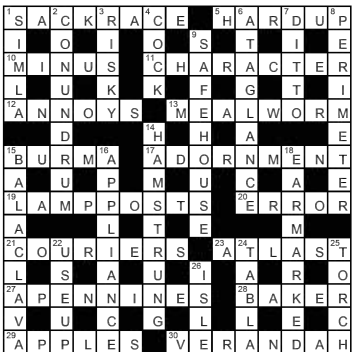


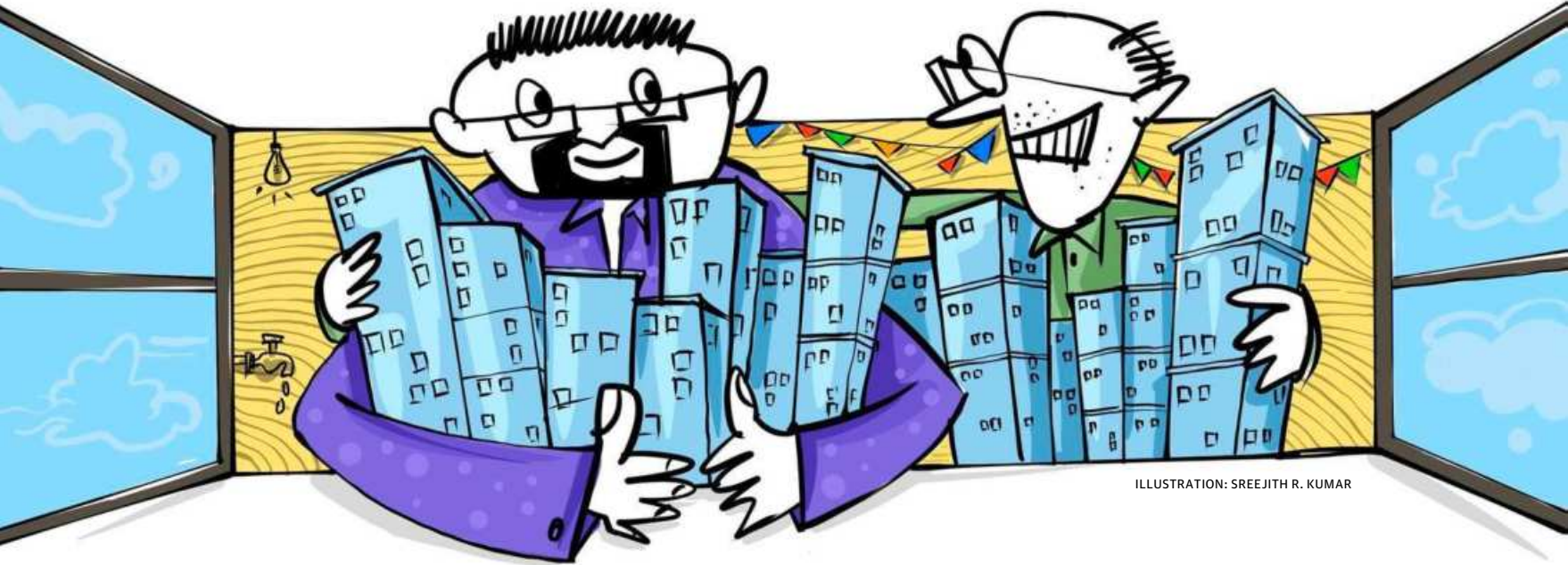
Across
7 One who heralds President's entree regularly before start of rally (9)
8 Uncertain European Union almost passed over (5)
10 Office fire curtailed with water (6)
11 Cold file reduced to a smaller size (8)
12 Secret agents triggered raid during flight (6)
13 Old lover's wrong to threaten for money (6)
15 A legal officer, one not working for commission (7)
17 Counting system, one included by Chief Minister in contract (7)
20 A person like Mother Teresa, left for India, with some inclination (6)
22 Free commercial break (6)
25 Shoemakers are cold, greedy consumers, not good (8)
26 Fair type, could be artificial! (6)
27 Rupee's in right position of supremacy! (5)
28 Bulimic's worried about slightly ungainly navel (9)

Down
1 Seller importing river fish (5)
2 Skin ailment epitomising, eschewing sin originally! (8)
3 Crazy dame had us petrified! (6)
4 State venture shipping European coal,

after being excavated! (7)
5 Flyer's back to rent capsule (6)
6 Extended as pure dot, possibly (9)
9 Weak English fellow at bazaar (6)
14 A message by police internally, about Pope (9)
16 Last girl's dwelling underground (6)
18 Indiscriminate firing over bill demeaning one's status (5,3)
19 Devil's most enthralled by reportedly exceptional mandarin (7)
21 A masculine President's hunt (6)
23 Mostly growing grape in reduced form (6)
24 Temper of Shakira's ex! (5)

SOLUTION NO. 64





Yesudas Pillai
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Residents welfare or cooperative societies, particularly those sprawling developments where a visionary developer decided that one society was not complicated enough and therefore created multiple societies within the same premises, are indeed among the most fascinating institutions ever created.

Think about it. A group of perfectly normal people buy apartments, move in with dreams of peace, greenery and community living, and within a few months, find themselves participating in something that resembles a combination of parliament, a start-up, a courtroom, a reality show, and occasionally a medieval kingdom.

A handful of brave souls volunteer for the managing committees. They begin their journey wanting to improve the community and soon discover that lifts, leaks, licences, landscaping, legal notices, labour issues, and resident expectations operate under the laws of quantum physics.

Another much larger group makes the wise decision not to contest elections. They then generously devote their time to explaining how every decision by the committee could have been taken better, faster, cheaper, and with greater vision.

Committee members gradually develop the belief that they are carrying the community on their shoulders. The rest of the residents gradually develop the belief that the committee is the reason the community needs carrying.

WhatsApp groups become remarkable centres of higher education. Within them reside experts in finance, law, governance, security, architecture, animal behaviour, event management, horticulture, geopolitics, and human psychology. Many of these qualifications are acquired between breakfast and lunch.

Every issue eventually finds a way to split into camps. Pet lovers and pet critics. Tower D and Tower E. Phase 1, Phase 2, and Phase 3. People who want change. People who want stability. People who want transparency. And people who want transparency only from others.

The most fascinating phenomenon emerges when communities start defining “us” and “them”. Walls already exist. Then the invisible walls are built. A gate becomes a border, an access card

Rule by committee

The raucous, cacophonic, and oddball ways in which residents’ associations of apartment complexes go about their tasks

becomes a visa. A visitor becomes a potential threat. A neighbouring society becomes a foreign nation.

The committees discuss barriers, restrictions, and control mechanisms with the seriousness usually reserved for national security councils. Initially everyone agrees. Then something inconvenient happens. People start interacting. They share elevators. They walk together. Children become friends. Pets become friends. Some even discover that the “other side” contains perfectly reasonable human beings.

Two schools of thought

This creates a crisis, as nothing is more dangerous to a territorial dispute than familiarity. Soon two schools of thought emerge within a committee. One believes boundaries must be defended forever as principles are at stake, and the other begins to suspect that the neighbours may not be enemies and that empathy is not a security risk.

Managing committee meetings become interesting. Voices become louder. Positions become firmer. Some committee members who are spectators choose sides. A few sensible people quietly exit the battleground altogether, having discovered that mental peace offers a higher return on investment than ideological victory.

Eventually one side prevails. It always does. The victorious camp celebrates. The defeated camp retreats. And few months later everyone discovers that the waterlogging remains unchanged, the false fire alarms still go off, the lifts still break down occasionally, and life goes on exactly as before.

The unofficial power centres are even more fascinating. The people who hold no position, carry no responsibility, sign no documents, attend no vendor meetings, and assume no accountability. But they can influence an entire debate in one sentence, “Let’s put it to vote as we know what many residents want.” No one ever meets these “many residents”. But their influence is undeniable.

And there is also another highly influential group. You can find any one of them say, “I don’t live in the complex currently, but still have strong views.” Their physical absence rarely diminishes their emotional participation.

Then there are the aristocrats of community living. The residents who believe maintenance charges are a universal exemption certificate. They will not clean up after themselves as someone is paid to do it. They will leave pet waste behind when no one is watching since housekeeping exists. They will flick cigarette butts and bread crumbs into landscaped areas as gravity is free. They will abuse security guards for enforcing rules as ownership, in their view, comes bundled with feudal privileges.

Irony is remarkable. People who passionately demand dignity, accountability, and respect from institutions occasionally struggle to extend the same courtesy to the guard standing at the gate.

History teaches us that kingdoms had courts. Modern societies have WhatsApp groups. The cast has changed. Human nature hasn’t. And, interestingly, beneath all the noise, almost everyone is trying to do what they believe is right.

The committee wants progress. The critics want accountability. The activists want causes. The power centres want influence. The experts want attention. And the silent majority just want the water pressure, lifts, and Wi-Fi to work.

Somewhere amid all this, the words “cooperative” and “welfare” quietly sit in the name of the society, patiently waiting for their turn on the agenda.

Community living is not about eliminating disagreements. It is about remembering that neighbours are not enemies, criticism is not contribution unless accompanied by participation, and authority is not leadership unless accompanied by humility. In the end, no one really owns the society. Everyone is merely temporary custodians of a place that will outlive committees, factions, victories, grievances, elections, and even the most passionate WhatsApp debates. And that perspective, unfortunately, is not available on the residents’ group as a downloadable PDF.

The tale of a moustache

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Recently, while returning home on the metro, something funny happened.

Though it was a Sunday, the train was packed. I did not get a seat. At the Majestic station in the heart of Bengaluru, many people got off and I finally got a seat. As I sat down and looked ahead, I saw a broad face adorned with a rather odd but impressive black moustache. The moustache was dark and well-shaped; but the face behind it was wrinkled with age.

“What the heck!” I wondered if he had dyed his moustache, but no, it wasn’t dyed. There was no real moustache at all. He had simply drawn one using *kajal* and came out into the crowd like that.

It took me a few seconds to fully register what I was seeing. By then, the man had also noticed me staring. The moment my mind realised it was a drawn moustache and not a real one, a childish grin flashed across my face. The man guessed that I was laughing at him. My laughter became even harder to conceal. That’s perhaps the normal response when our funny crimes get outed. Young boys have the freedom to laugh in such situations. But having entered middle age now, where do I get that liberty from?

If I had a friend with me, we would have chatted, laughed, and brushed aside the situation easily. But there was no one. Before the man could get offended, I had to do something. Like a godsend, the train doors opened. Without even checking which station it was, I jumped out of the door and burst out laughing freely on the platform.

The world is indeed a comic place.

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There was a time when village wells were not just a source of water but also an important part of everyday life and happiness. For many, some of the sweetest childhood memories are connected to the well. After playing for long hours under the hot sun, running in open fields, climbing trees, or playing cricket and hide-and-seek with friends, we would go near the well feeling thirsty and tired. Someone would pull up a bucket of cool water, and we would drink happily from a steel tumbler. That water felt fresh, sweet, and comforting in a way that is difficult to explain today. Modern bottled water may be clean and convenient, but it rarely carries the feeling of those simple moments.

The well was never just a structure made of stone and water. It was a living place where people met, spoke, laughed, and shared life. In many Indian villages and small towns, wells stood at the centre of community life.

Beautiful mornings

Early mornings near the well had a beauty of their own. Women gathered with buckets and pots, talking about family matters, festivals, village news, and daily life while drawing water. Elders sat nearby discussing farming, weather, and

Slaking the thirst for connections

Wells had been the town squares of yore where people met and talked



local happenings. Children played around freely, filling the place with energy and laughter.

For us children, the well was also a place of fun and friendship. After drinking water, playful moments often started. One friend would suddenly splash water on another’s face and soon everyone joined in the running around to escape getting wet. During hot afternoons, even a few drops of cool water on the face felt refreshing and joyful. Those moments looked ordinary then but today they return as beautiful memories. Looking back now, we realise how happiness

often came from the smallest things.

The well also silently taught lessons about togetherness and responsibility. Since the water belonged to everyone, people naturally cared for it. Families ensured the surroundings remained clean. Leaves and dirt were removed and waste never entered



The well was not just a structure made of stone and water. It was a living place where people met, spoke, laughed, and shared life

the water. Everyone understood that if the well became dirty, the whole community would suffer. Without formal lessons, people learned the importance of care and respect for nature.

However, times slowly changed. With modernisation, borewells, water pipelines, and overhead tanks, access to water became easier and faster. Slowly, dependence on traditional wells reduced. In many places, wells were closed or abandoned. Some disappeared completely to make space for roads, buildings and houses. In cities and towns, many children today may never experience drawing water from a well or gathering around one with friends.

Forlorn structures

With the passing of time, many old wells now stand quietly, forgotten in corners or hidden behind growing plants and walls. Yet, for those who grew up around them, seeing an old well often brings back memories of another time of summer afternoons and laughter shared with friends and those small joys remain deeply remembered. The vanishing wells of our communities remind us that progress should not mean forgetting the past. Modern life is important, but preserving traditional wells can help protect our environment and community spirit. In saving wells, we save the closeness, and innocence of those beautiful days.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

These walks achieve something textbooks rarely manage: they show queerness as part of India’s mainstream past, not as a Western import. (‘On India’s rainbow trail’; July 12) Monuments like Jamali Kamali deserve formal heritage protection precisely because such histories are fragile and easily erased. State tourism boards could usefully partner with these walk organisers instead of leaving the work entirely to individual enthusiasts.

A. Myilsami

Flicker of hope

The anguish and despair of novelist Tabish Khair, about the tragic displacement of people and their travails in Gaza, comes out loud and clear in the interview. (‘Ghosts of Gaza’; July 12). Millions of Gazans have become “refugees” within their country. Khair’s statement that restoration remains a human possibility strikes a note of optimism.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

History lessons

Munis D. Faruqui’s archival approach is a welcome corrective to a debate long dominated by selective memory. (‘Aurangzeb never forced non-Muslim subjects to convert’; July 12) History textbooks in schools would benefit from this same rigour, teaching students to distinguish political motive from religious persecution rather than flattening centuries of complexity into convenient slogans.

S.M. Jeeva

Forgotten art

It is heartening that Intach workshops are reviving Patna Kalam, but private

collections locked away in trunks defeat the purpose. (‘Bihar’s everyday canvas, revived’; July 12) Bihar Museum’s proposed permanent gallery should be expedited, and works held in the V&A and the Met should be digitised for public access here.

M. Barathi

Good model

Arun Pai’s approach, solving problems quietly instead of merely criticising authorities, deserves emulation in every Indian city. (‘Arun Pai: pavement dreams’; July 12) Civic bodies elsewhere should study his model of partnering citizens with officials rather than treating public participation as either confrontation or charity.

Abbharna Barathi

Greater shift

The nested bar trend reflects a broader shift towards valuing depth over volume in how we spend leisure time. (‘Everyone’s loving bars within bars’; July 12) What strikes me the most is the pricing transparency, since guests know exactly what personalised craft costs, a lesson hospitality across other sectors could learn from.

Swathi Senthilkumar

Fragile ecosystems

Resorts funding marine biologists and coral restoration experts show tourism need not come at the cost of the environment. (‘Mauritius and the conservation concierge’; July 12) Indian coastal states with similar fragile ecosystems, Goa and the Andamans particularly, should mandate comparable conservation investment as a licensing condition for luxury properties.

S.P. Suganya Devi



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Medicine and the art of listening

The patient is in the room, but everyone else is speaking

Maria K. Jimmy

Joy and agony of living alone

It is a transformative experience, teaching you not only independence but also resilience

Mahima Roselin Varghese

Towards self-reliance in old age

There’s nothing more satisfying than self-help, doing whatever one can do around the home

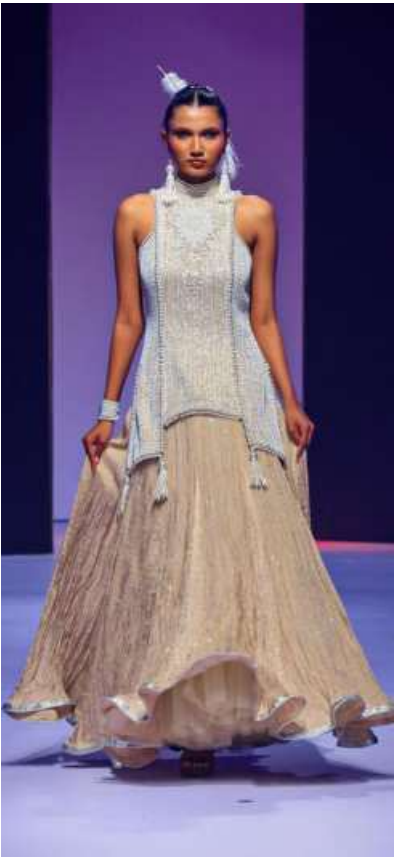
George Netto

Stillness amid the flux

The secret to surviving the daily grind is in the steady rhythm of personal morning routines

Praveenaa A. Sundaram

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Jishnu Bandyopadhyay

Before Colombo had a fashion week, and much before sustainable fashion became a buzzword-riddled marketing category anyone could buy into, Ajai Vir Singh often argued that a country famous for making other people's clothes could also be trusted with its own name on the label.

Through the years, Singh, who went to Sri Lanka as an expatriate in the 90s, eyed a nascent market with a relatively modest pool of contemporary designers and built a fashion week. Everything Colombo Fashion Week (CFW) has tried to become since – a South Asian design hub, a sustainability showcase, and now a BRICS-adjacent cultural platform – is built on the belief that a manufacturing economy can also be a moral axis of mindful style.

Earlier this year, as I sat through the shows at CFW's latest edition, this future-forward ethos was apparent. But it also left me a little apprehensive about the future of such exceptional talent. Unlike India and its fashion weeks with hefty production budgets, how would they get the attention they deserve? More importantly, why were fashion insiders not talking about Sri Lanka with more fervour yet?

"In Colombo, you may see a designer's collection that was created for the ramp, and that's likely the end of it. There's not necessarily an extension waiting," says Annika Fernando, who has run the cult multi-brand store Paradise Road in the island country for close to 15 years. "A designer here might make and sell just six dresses a month."

What reframes the story

Sri Lanka's own garment factories, the same ones producing for behemoths such as Nike and Victoria's Secret at an industrial scale, aren't built to handle a local designer's 15-piece batch. Fernando explains that the factories are calibrated for global brands' volumes and, due to other restrictions in place, stops local designers from tapping into the same production line.

That's the paradox around which I kept circling. An island with more garment manufacturing infrastructure than anywhere else in South Asia (direct garment-sector jobs per capita stand at roughly 1 per 63 residents, according to a report by the U.S. International Trade Administration) cannot provide adequate support for its own designers to scale. Ironically, however, that's also what allows Colombo to function more like an atelier culture than a retail pipeline.

Strong domestic market

Meanwhile, the other problem that has been holding Sri Lanka back seems to be solving itself. Indian designer Rajesh Pratap Singh, who was a part of CFW this year, is blunt about what Colombo needs: "A strong



(Top and right) Designs by Mikail Hameed; Sonali Dharmawardena; Payal Pratap; Rajesh Pratap Singh; Rizwan Beyg; and (above, L-R) Annika Fernando; Ajai Vir Singh; and Fazeena Rajabdeen. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

domestic market that is independent of markets outside." India's fashion industry has had decades and a billion-plus population's headstart on domestic demand, but Sri Lanka's 22 million are only now starting to buy local in a big way. (A surge in national pride, positive economic shifts, and a design renaissance are helping this.)

CFW director Fazeena Rajabdeen says roughly 90% of the style-conscious crowd wear Sri Lankan labels today, against what she describes as near-zero 20 years ago.

Don't get it twisted; Sri Lanka is far more than its struggles. If India's fashion imagination runs towards abundance – embellishments, embroidery –



Sri Lanka's runs towards a modern yet rooted restraint. Nearly everyone I speak to describes that restraint as a design philosophy rather than what many might perceive as a limitation. "We're not as textile-rich as India," says Fernando. "That's not our greatest strength." She traces it back to a talk she attended in Mumbai, where the consensus was that Sri Lankan design is defined by conscious editing and a pared-back aesthetic, which can be tied directly to the island's other exports, like its tropical-modernist architecture – the Geoffrey Bawa lineage of clean lines.

The craft doing most of the talking is batik. The wax-resist dyeing arrived via Dutch



colonial trade routes around the turn of the 19th century, originating in what is now Indonesia, and then evolved, much as it did in India, into something specifically local. Darshi Keerthisena of Buddhi Batiks describes Sri Lankan batik as shaped by "generations of knowledge, patience, and a distinctly Sri Lankan sensibility" – not something she's interested in scaling.

A cultural cocktail

Where Colombo's silhouettes diverge most obviously from its counterparts across South Asia, is occasion. Bridal and

heavy occasion wear (the commercial engine of Indian fashion weeks) is far less central here; what dominates instead is resort and everyday wear built for a chic coastal life. "Our goal is to juxtapose aspirational, whimsical pieces against these landscapes that look like you're in a picture book. So, the clothes and the coastline are given equal



footing," says Radhika Perera-Hernandez of Loïs London. She was born in London, grew up in New York and is now proudly producing her brands in her motherland, Sri Lanka.

Another distinction: the batik-via-Dutch-Indonesia route is a useful reminder that Sri Lanka's design language sits, as it always has, at a meeting point of Indian Ocean trade. With Arab and South Indian merchants, then Portuguese, Dutch and British colonisers. Colombo promotes and nurtures this cultural cocktail, showing the likes of Pakistani designer Rizwan Beyg, whose embroidery initiative, Bunyaad, sources its entire label from 250 rural women artisans. Or Chinese designer Ji Cheng, who went home to Shanghai after CFW with batik samples and a plan to fold Sri Lankan patterning into her work after Chinese buyers kept asking where to buy the "Indian pieces" she'd picked up in Colombo.

None of these reads like a lesser Paris or Milan playing catch-up, but a different kind of network that is South-South rather than South-facing-West. Globally, the market has caught up to what Colombo was already doing by necessity – in line with Fernando's observation that "buyers now want what they don't instantly recognise" over a logo they do, which is really a description of the same appetite driving interest in slow, artisanal production everywhere. Sri Lanka just never had the industrial scale to do fashion any other way.

The Mumbai-based writer, artist and editor reports on fashion and culture.

The first thing you notice about these temples is what surrounds them. Victorian lawns, symmetrical fountains that recall Mughal pleasure gardens, a lotus pond shaped like the flower but with no blooms in it. There are no fruit-bearing trees that can attract monkeys, birds and insects; no flowering trees that can attract snakes. At the centre, beneath a cluster of white marble or pink sandstone peaks, stands the temple, with fluttering flags. In the 20th century, they rose not just in India, but also in London, in Dubai, in American cities. They make very specific statements about aspirational Hindus.

Marble has never been a traditional material in Hindu sacred architecture. In Tamil Nadu, the great storied temples were built in granite. In Odisha, the material was khondalite. In Karnataka, soapstone. Across North India, red and yellow sandstone. Marble was, in fact, long associated with animal bones and was deliberately shunned by traditional artisans.

White of piety

It is the Shvetambara Jain community of merchants who first built temples of marble, on Mount Abu and Girnar in Gujarat, from the 10th century onwards, during the reign of the Solanki kings. As followers of white-robed teachers,



FROM CULT TO CULTURE

The rise of marble temples

And why these communities yearned to build temples that could match the spires of churches and the minarets of mosques

building temples of white marble seemed fairly logical. Marble images within were bedecked with inlay, gold and gems.

When Islam rose in India, marble became a popular export, used for tombstones and to make the mihrab niche

on the qibla wall of mosques, pointing to Mecca. Many Muslim Sultanates had Jains as their treasurers and mint-masters. Marble soon became a luxury material for kings. For Sufi saints, white embodied simplicity and piety.

A hall in the Adinatha Jain temple in Khajuraho; and (below) the Birla Mandir in Kolkata. (ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES)



In Orchha in Madhya Pradesh, older Hindu temples were made of sandstone. Only in the last hundred years did Hindu traders from the Aravalli regions, where marble is abundant, start mimicking their Jain rivals. This gave rise to the Jaipur style. First popularised by the Birla family, it is now carried forward by the Sompura architects who work with both the Swaminarayan and Jain communities across India and the world. It is now tough to distinguish a Hindu temple from a Jain one in most North Indian cities. There is nothing remotely Eastern or Southern in the styling. It has become the vocabulary of Sanatana Dharma, or Neo-Hinduism.

Wherever these temples appear, a particular form of Hinduism follows. One that equates vegetarian food with purity and meat-eating with pollution. One that presents itself as the correction of historical wrongs. The patrons, recollect how during Islamic rule, in Gujarat and Rajasthan, deities were hidden in Rajput mansions. The *haveli* did not announce the presence of the divine like ancient temples. These communities yearned to build temples that could match, visually and symbolically, the spires of mosques. Their temples are, therefore, described as Shikhara-baddha: displaying mountain peaks.

The divine couple disappears

To understand the significance of this style of temple architecture, we have to know what the Hindu temple originally was. Early Hindu temples were natural: sacred groves, confluences of rivers, and faraway grottos. Stone temples appeared in India roughly 1,500 years ago. The roof represented the Himalayas, the doorways bore symbols of the Ganga and Yamuna, and the walls depicted stories from the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*, epics whose events unfolded in Arya-varta. When Brahmins migrated south, they brought this sacred northern geography with them through architecture.

When conquerors broke temples in the North to make way for mosques, kings of the South responded by building massive walls around temple complexes. On the gateways rose towering *gopurams*, covered in thousands of painted figures, a defiant counter-statement directed at the northern iconoclasts.

At its core, the Hindu temple was a Tantrik shrine. Within, Shiva and Parvati sat in intimate symbolic union, expressed as the linga set in the yoni trough. The Vaishnava temple softened this erotic expression into romance, separating the shrines of god and goddess so that they

could be ceremonially reunited in chariot processions and boat festivals. The divine couple was the organising principle of the sacred space.

The Muslims were not just against idol worship; they were also monotheists and preferred the male vocabulary. That influence shapes much of modern Hindu temple vocabulary. The mosque was a prayer hall, not the house of god as a temple wall. Modern temples became prayer halls and divine courts (*durbars*).

In the Jaipur marble temple, the intimacy of the divine couple disappears. Goddesses stand separately, formally, barely touching. The female form is often absent entirely. Instead, the gods are presented as solitary figures, as celibate monk-teachers, as sons with invisible mothers.

The marble temple, with its opulent chandeliers, its house-keeping staff and industrial efficiency, does not simply reflect a community's wealth or aesthetic preference. It encodes a doctrine, and a politics. The question worth asking is not whether these temples are beautiful. They are. The question is what they are saying, and to whom.



Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.